PART 6 OF 11 · LAYER 1: KEEP THE HOUSE DRY

Away from home and hurricane season

THE SIMPLE VERSION

When you go away, leave the air conditioner on.
A house with no AC gets damp, and damp houses grow mold.

- **Never turn the AC off for a long absence,** and leave the fan on AUTO. Choose a setting that runs the AC or a dehumidifier on purpose (see the table).[1]
- **Use a remote humidity sensor or smart thermostat alert** so you know if humidity rises or the AC fails while you are away.

What Florida research found for vacant homes

The Florida Solar Energy Center tested real homes and aimed to keep humidity below 70 percent essentially all the time and below 65 percent most of the time.[1]

Away setting	Result in the study	Our take
AC off (house floats)	Could not reliably stay below 65 percent; two of three homes saw long periods at 70 percent and above.	Do not use.
Thermostat at 83 to 85°F	Worked in hot, sunny weather but not in cooler, cloudy, humid weather.	Not enough on its own.
AC runs about 2 hours a day in the early morning	Effective and energy-efficient humidity control.	Good choice with a programmable thermostat.
Dehumidifier on a humidistat or timer	Good results with the lowest overall energy use.	Good choice; drain it to a sink or drain.
Humidistat that calls the AC	Works, but a failed or mis-set control overcooled one house below the outdoor dew point and caused widespread condensation and mold.	Use only with a low-temperature limit, about 77°F.

Summary of FSEC-PF-438-09. Your HVAC contractor should confirm settings for your specific equipment.[1]

Hurricane season

THE SIMPLE VERSION

Big storms bring lots of rain and wind.
We get the house ready before, and we dry it fast after.

When	What to do
Before the season	Check roof, window, slider, and storm-shutter seals and track drainage. Flush the AC drain line. Put a hygrometer or remote sensor in place, and have a dehumidifier and wet/dry vacuum ready.
Before cleanup	Re-enter only when it is safe, with no structural, electrical, or gas hazards. Take photos of the home and belongings for insurance.[2]
During cleanup	Wear at least an N95 respirator, goggles, and gloves. Keep children out of cleanup work. Run generators outside, at least 20 feet from the house.[2]
Drying	Dry everything within 24 to 48 hours if you can. Throw away porous items that were wet with floodwater and cannot be cleaned and dried in that time.[2]
Before restarting HVAC	If the system took on floodwater, have it checked and cleaned first; turning it on can spread mold through the house.[2]

After a storm: signs a wall or ceiling may be wet inside

Water often travels inside an assembly before it shows. These are the clues we follow during a moisture investigation. If you see one, take a photo, note the date, and call us.

- Stains, rings, or bubbling paint on ceilings and walls, especially below windows, sliders, and shutter tracks.
- Swollen or separated baseboards, soft or crumbly drywall, and damp carpet edges or rusty carpet tack strip.
- Musty odors that come back after cleaning, or that are stronger in one room or closet.
- Condensation, dripping, or dark spots around AC supply registers and the air handler closet.
- Cracks, gaps, or white salt deposits on stucco, and failed sealant around windows, doors, and wall penetrations.

Your next step

Before your next trip or before June 1, choose an away setting from the table and test it for a few days while you are home. After any storm, look for the signs on this page within 24 hours.

Sources for this part

1. FSEC, Effectiveness and Energy Efficiency of Humidity Control Approaches in Vacant Homes (FSEC-PF-438-09). http://fsec.ucf.edu/en/publications/pdf/FSEC-PF-438-09.pdf
2. CDC/EPA/FEMA/HUD/NIH, Homeowner's and Renter's Guide to Mold Cleanup After Disasters. https://www.cdc.gov/mold/pdfs/Homeowners_and_Renters_Guide.pdf